Incense sticks/cones: HMTc Standard

Karen Pendergrass · · Heavy Metal Tested & Certified, Institute of Contaminant Standards

CITE AS

Pendergrass K. "Incense sticks/cones: HMTc Standard". Heavy Metal Certified, 2026. https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/incense--sticks-cones. CC BY 4.0.

CORRESPONDENCE

Corrections are logged publicly on the article page, each with its date, the affected value, and the source that resolved it.

KEYWORDS

heavy metals, food safety, dietary exposure

PUBLICATION HISTORY

This revision 2026-08.

Abstract

The Heavy Metal Tested & Certified heavy-metal-safety standard for incense sticks/cones in Home Air and Inhalation-Adjacent Products, evaluated on as sold, micrograms of element per kilogram of the emitting material (the fragrance concentrate, wax, gel, botanical mass or refill charge that is aerosolised, evaporated or combusted), with component-level screening of the article's non-emitting parts; a content screen on the article and its refill, never an emission rate, a per-actuation dose or an indoor-air concentration. 4 of 11 panel analytes publish a numeric limit taken from the strictest applicable government maximum; the remainder are held under mandatory control or a substantiated not-material determination.

1 | How every number on this standard is set

HMTc Method v2.0 (government-limit-only initial setting: the strictest applicable sovereign maximum for this exact product form in its native basis; disclosed read-across where the exact cell is unregulated; control where neither a sovereign number nor a supportable near-neighbour analogue exists; never occurrence-derived)

2 | Master limit table

All values in ppb (µg/kg), as sold basis. A brand meeting every value qualifies for the mark.

ANALYTE	TIER	HMTC LIMIT	BASIS
Lead (Pb)	Tier 1	500	human-grade read-across (US-CO)
Cadmium (Cd)	Tier 1	200	human-grade read-across (US-CO)

Total arsenic (tAs)	Tier 2	200	human-grade read-across (US-CO)
Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	Tier 1	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Mercury, total (tHg)	Tier 1	100	human-grade read-across (US-CO)
Methylmercury (MeHg)	Tier 1	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Nickel (Ni)	Tier 2	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Tin (Sn)	Tier 2	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Aluminium (Al)	Tier 2	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum
Total chromium (Cr)	Tier 2	600	screening ceiling (US-MD)
Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	Tier 2	control	measured every lot; no human-food maximum

3 | Derivation — where each number comes from

Every cell traces to one named sovereign maximum level (the strictest for the nearest analog), or to an explicit control, not-material, or species-bounded determination. No occurrence statistic selects a certification value.

ANALYTE	HMTC	SOVEREIGN ANALOG /
Lead (Pb)	500	US-CO — human-food analog
Cadmium (Cd)	200	US-CO — human-food analog
Total arsenic (tAs)	200	US-CO — human-food analog
Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	control	No government sets an inorganic-arsenic content maximum for any inhaled consumer product or any home-air product. Every route-scoped inhaled-product instrument regulates arsenic as the unspeciated total: Colorado, California, Maryland, Massachusetts, Nevada and Israel all publish total arsenic and none of them speciates, so there is no inorganic-arsenic cell anywhere to read across from. The article and component instruments checked were EU RoHS Directive 2011/65/EU Annex II (lead, cadmium, total mercury and hexavalent chromium in the homogeneous materials of electrical and electronic equipment), the EU Batteries Regulation Annex I (mercury, cadmium and lead in batteries), REACH Annex XVII entry 23 (cadmium in synthetic polymers, paint and painted articles), REACH Annex XVII entry 20 (organotin

 CC BY 4.0

Mercury, total (tHg)	100	US-CO — human-food analog
Methylmercury (MeHg)	control	No government sets a methylmercury content limit for any air-care product, and every methylmercury instrument on the register is scoped to fish and other aquatic animals at values far above the 100 ug/kg total-mercury ceiling this row already carries, so no read-across from them would bind anything: methylmercury is a component of total mercury and cannot exceed it. A NOT-MATERIAL determination is not available for this row either, and this is a deliberate departure from the twelve manufactured-formulation rows in this category that do carry one. This row admits marine-derived and wild-harvested natural material - ambergris and other marine-animal-derived perfumery fixatives in incense, dried seaweed, shell, coral and other marine decorative elements in potpourri, and undetermined natural inputs on the residual row - so a categorical claim that no methylation pathway exists would be false for part of the row and would fail the not-material substantiation gate. Control is the fail-safe and is what is published. The companion instrument recorded is the Hong Kong Cap. 132V methylmercury maximum for fish, which is named to show that the only sovereign methylmercury cells anywhere are fish-scoped; it is not this row's ceiling and its 500 ug/kg value is five times the total-mercury ceiling this row already publishes.

Nickel (Ni)	control	No government sets a nickel content maximum for any inhaled consumer product or any home-air product. Every route-scoped inhaled-product instrument on the register omits nickel entirely, including Maryland's inhalation-route table, which publishes lead, arsenic, mercury, cadmium and total chromium but no nickel. The nearest nickel instruments were checked and each fails on basis or on route: the EU Toy Safety Directive nickel values are element MIGRATION limits from toy material under EN 71-3, not content limits; REACH Annex XVII entry 27 governs nickel RELEASE RATE from skin-piercing and prolonged--skin-contact articles; Korea MFDS 2025-63 and 2024-9 set nickel content limits for cosmetics on a dermal basis; and EU Regulation (EU) 2024/1987 sets dietary nickel maximum levels on an ingestion basis. No conversion between a migration limit, a release rate, a dermal cosmetic limit and a total-content limit for an inhaled product is defensible, and none is performed. A not-material determination is rejected: Nickel is material here: charcoal and coal-derived combustible fillers are a well-established nickel source, clay binders carry soil-derived nickel, and this category's own contamination--platform description names nickel as a dirty-platform metal for combustion emitters. Smouldering delivers it to the breathing zone as a fine particulate. The cell is a control. No occupational exposure limit, indoor-air guideline or ambient-air standard was used, and none was converted into a product ceiling: an air concentration is not a product content maximum and HMTc does not manufacture one from the other.

Tin (Sn)	control	No government sets a total-tin content maximum for any inhaled consumer product or any home-air product. The tin instruments on the register were checked and each fails on basis or on scope: the Codex, EU, Hong Kong and Japan canned-food tin maximum levels govern tin dissolved from tinplate INTO A FOOD on a dietary as-consumed basis; the EU Toy Safety Directive tin values are EN 71-3 migration limits from toy material; and REACH Annex XVII entry 20 restricts ORGANOTIN SPECIES expressed as tin in mixtures and articles supplied to the general public, which does directly cover the articles in this row but is a species restriction at 0.1 percent by weight rather than a total-tin content ceiling, and adopting 1,000,000 ug/kg as this row's tin limit would be to publish a number that protects nobody. It is recorded as the companion instrument and enforced as a precondition instead. A not-material determination is rejected: Tin is material here: tin-bearing driers and stabilisers in surface dyes and lacquers, metallised packaging in direct contact with the sticks, and organotin residues in binder systems. The cell is a control. No occupational exposure limit, indoor-air guideline or ambient-air standard was used, and none was converted into a product ceiling: an air concentration is not a product content maximum and HMTc does not manufacture one from the other.

Aluminium (Al)	control	No government sets an aluminium content maximum for any inhaled consumer product or any home-air product. The aluminium instruments on the register were checked and each fails on basis or on route: the EU Toy Safety Directive aluminium values are EN 71-3 element migration limits from toy material, and the dietary and food-additive aluminium provisions are calibrated to oral intake and oral absorption. Aluminium is also the panel analyte for which route-transfer is least defensible in principle, because a dietary aluminium limit is written against gastrointestinal absorption of well under one percent, which does not describe deposition in the respiratory tract. HMTc states that asymmetry and does NOT convert it into a number: no exposure model, no percentile and no precautionary adjustment produces a value here, and none of the route-scoped inhaled-product instruments publishes aluminium at all. A not-material determination is rejected: Aluminium is material here: clay, kaolin and talc binders are aluminosilicates by composition, aluminium-pigment and metallised surface decoration is common on premium and festival grades, and aluminium concentrates in the ash. The cell is a control. No occupational exposure limit, indoor-air guideline or ambient-air standard was used, and none was converted into a product ceiling: an air concentration is not a product content maximum and HMTc does not manufacture one from the other.
Total chromium (Cr)	600	government maximum level

Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	control	Hexavalent chromium is never a panel screen number in this programme; it is the toxic species reached by reflex speciation from total chromium. No government sets a hexavalent-chromium content maximum for any inhaled consumer product or any home-air product: Maryland publishes plain total chromium for the inhalation route and does not speciate, and no other route-scoped instrument publishes chromium in any form. The nearest hexavalent-chromium instruments were checked and each fails on basis or on scope: EU RoHS (0.1 percent by weight in the homogeneous materials of electrical and electronic equipment), REACH Annex XVII entry 72 Appendix 12 (1 mg/kg after extraction in consumer clothing and skin-contact textiles), REACH entry 47 for leather articles, the EU Toy Safety Directive EN 71-3 migration limits, and drinking-water maximum contaminant levels expressed per litre. No occupational exposure limit, indoor-air guideline or ambient-air standard was used, and none was converted into a product ceiling: an air concentration is not a product content maximum and HMTc does not manufacture one from the other. A not-material determination is rejected: Chromium is material here and this is the highest-risk hexavalent-chromium cell in the category: chrome-bearing dyes and mordants are used on incense surfaces, clay binders carry trivalent chromium, and a smouldering oxidising glow front at several hundred degrees is precisely the condition under which trivalent chromium is oxidised to the hexavalent state and released as a respirable particulate. The cell is a control with reflex speciation and a zero-tolerance disposition.

4 | Cite this standard

Pendergrass, K. "Incense sticks/cones." In Heavy Metal Tested & Certified (HMTc) Home Air and Inhalation-Adjacent Products standard, version 1.0 (2026-08-17). Institute of Contaminant Standards (ICS), 2026.

References

[1] US-CO — human-food maximum levels
Binds Pb, Cd, tAs, tHg. Strictest applicable human-food sovereign maximum for the nearest analog.
MAXIMUM LEVEL

STATUS AND LICENCE

Editorially reviewed in-house; no external peer review has been completed on this reference. Published as a preprint with its review state tracked on the article page. Released under CC BY 4.0.

COMPETING INTERESTS

This briefing is published by the Heavy Metal Tested & Certified (HMTc) program, operated by the Institute of Contaminant Standards. Its statements about government regulations, toxicology, and occurrence are sourced to the cited primary and expert-body records and to the independently maintained Heavy Metal Index; the program's own certification thresholds are not used as evidence for any factual claim made here.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The works this reference draws on are listed in full in the references above and on the briefing page at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/incense--sticks-cones. Primary legal instruments and expert-body assessments are named with their public identifiers; the underlying occurrence and toxicology corpus is maintained on the Heavy Metal Index.

PUBLICATION HISTORY

This revision 2026-08. The full dated record is maintained at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/-incense-sticks-cones.